

The Roman historian Plutarch wrote that of all Rome's ancient kings, Servius was naturally the least suited to monarchy and the least desiring of it. He was made king only through Fortuna's favor. While he was still a child his head shone with a glow like lightning. This was said to be a "token of his birth from fire," and a good omen pointing to his future accession to the throne. When the old king on his deathbed suddenly appointed Servius king, Tanaquil shouted his accession to the throne from a palace window known as the *Porta Fenestella*. He wanted to resign, but Tanaquil prevented him from doing so by making him swear that he would remain in power. Thus, says Plutarch, Servius owed to Fortuna his kingship, which he received unexpectedly, and was compelled to retain against his will. Servius in turn built the first temples and shrines to her, establishing Fortuna's Roman cult. For his devotion, Fortuna is said to have visited his bedchamber through the *Porta Fenestella*, the same palace window from which Tanaquil declared him king. Servius was indeed divinely favored.

Plutarch says that Servius knew "[f]ortune is of great moment, or rather, she is everything in human affairs" because it was through good fortune that he had ascended from slave to king.² In Roman mythology Fortuna was the goddess of fate, and the personification of chance. She turned the *Rota Fortunae*—the Wheel of Fortune—which dictated the destiny of man. The wheel had four stages—*Regnabo*, *Regno*, *Regnavi*, *Sum sine regno* (I shall reign, I reign, I reigned, I am without a kingdom)³—and turned constantly, moving man from one stage to the next. Fortuna's "wildly spinning wheel" was, according to Shakespeare, "to signify to you, which is the moral of it, that she is turning, and inconstant, and mutability, and variation."⁴ Fortuna was also regarded as fickle, and cruel because she didn't make a distinction between the worthy and the unworthy. Seneca warned in the *Agamemnon*⁵:

O Fortune, who dost bestow the throne's high boon with mocking hand, in dangerous and doubtful state thou settest the too exalted. Never have sceptres obtained calm peace or certain tenure; care on care weighs them down, and ever do fresh storms vex their souls.

...

Whatever Fortune has raised on high, she lifts but to bring low. Modest estate has longer life; then happy he whoe'er, content with the common lot, with safe breeze hugs the shore, and, fearing to trust his skiff to the wider sea, with unambitious oar keeps close to land.

Servius should have taken heed of Seneca's warning. The coda to his story is that Fortuna eventually abandoned him in brutal fashion. His daughter, Tullia, and his son-in-law, Tarquin the Arrogant, had him murdered in the